Best Laid Plans

Your job is to predict, *before you start*, the week the customer will accept your work. Then run the project and find out how right you were.

Step 1
Open and read
Open the link, enter the code on the board, and read The Contract tab. Every tab is open from the start.

Step 2
Plan, then commit
Choose a plan, check whatever you think you need on the desk, then commit three numbers.

Step 3
Run the line
One decision round per week until the customer accepts, or the contract is cancelled.

Step 4
Stop and sketch
At "finished," don't reveal. Sketch your answer and wait. Then download your results.

THE CONTRACT



200 units · 4 crews to start · $5.00M budget + $0.5M credit (past it: bankrupt) · each crew costs $50k a week

BEFORE WEEK 1: YOUR PLAN, THEN THREE NUMBERS

Your plan: crews to add at the start (none, +1, +2, +3); inspection (0, 10, 20 or 30%); second shift (none, late weeks, every week). You can change course later.

The desk: The Contract · Status Report · Project Controls (burn-down, defect control chart) · What-if Planner · Team Chat (five approaches) · Ask an AI · Last 5 Contracts · Records (40 past contracts, downloadable as a CSV). They disagree; deciding which to trust is the exercise.

① The week
The week you think the customer accepts all 200 units.

② An 80% range
Earliest to latest week, so that you'd bet **4 to 1** the outcome lands inside it.

③ Chance of week 12
Your honest probability, 0–100%, that it's accepted by the deadline.

EACH WEEK YOU MAY

MOVE	EFFECT	COST
Add crews (up to 3)	More capacity, but the whole line runs at 70% for 2 weeks while they learn. Beyond 4 crews, every crew gets a bit less efficient.	$100k each
Release a crew	Lower weekly cost	$50k
Second shift	+30% output. From the second straight week, tired crews make more defects.	$20k / crew
Inspect 0–30%	Moves capacity from building to checking. Finds defects while they're cheap.	capacity
Move your forecast	Update your estimate. Only your week-1 commitment is judged. After key events, tap Keep or Change.	free

HOW YOUR FORECAST IS JUDGED

No points. At the end you see three verdicts on the forecast you committed before week 1:

Your week	How many weeks off, early or late.
Your 80% range	Did it hold? How wide was it, beside the record's range?
Your chance of week 12	What you said, against what happened.

A wide range holds easily; a narrow range that holds is the skill. **Delivery** shows how the company did: 100, minus 12 per week late and 1 per $50k over budget; zero if never delivered.

One game can't score a forecaster. The room's hit rate is the real score.

WHAT AN 80% RANGE MEANS

If you made ten forecasts like this one, about **eight** should land inside your range and about **two** outside. A range that never misses is too wide; one that usually misses is too narrow.

HONEST BEATS BOLD

Say what you actually believe. Across the room, your 80% ranges should hold about 8 times in 10, and your 60% calls should come true about 6 in 10. Too bold and the room misses; too timid and your ranges say nothing.

ROOM RULES

- Play alone. No talking about numbers until the reveal.
- Use the code on the board.
- Only your **first** play counts. Download its results file (run 1) before you replay.
- At the end, keep your results screen open: your instructor will ask for a show of hands.

THE SKETCH (ON PAPER, BEFORE YOU REVEAL)

The week you think it was accepted: _____ Did your 80% range hold? Yes / No How sure are you? ____ / 100
What did you mostly look at when you committed? _____
What was your plan, and why? _____

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AFTER THE REVEAL

Every forecast is seen through a frame that can see some things and is blind to others.

FRAMES YOU COULD HAVE USED TONIGHT

The pace
Extrapolate the current rate. **Sees** output so far. **Blind to** defects and scope changes. The trap: anchoring.

The plan
Run the movie step by step. **Sees** your choices. **Blind to** everything outside the plan. A plan is a chain: ten 90% steps ≈ 35%.

The dashboard
"Percent complete." **Sees** what was built. **Blind to** what will pass. The 90% syndrome.

One vivid case
"Last time it took..." **Sees** one real outcome. **Blind to** whether you'll play like it.

The record
What happened to things like this. **Sees** what the plan forgot. **Blind to** plans no one has tried, and to true novelty.

Models, crowds, AI
Regression, simulation, colleagues, chatbots. **Only as good as** what they're fed, and averaging helps only if they err differently.

CALIBRATION IS NOT ACCURACY



Bar = 80% range · dot = what happened

Hire forecaster B. Judge forecasters on many forecasts, never on one outcome.

WHAT A 90% FORECAST MEANS

In 2016 forecasters gave Clinton roughly 85–90%. She lost. That alone doesn't make them wrong. A 10–15% event happens one time in seven to ten. The question is never "did the 90% happen?" It's "of all the 90% calls, how many came true?"

THE FOUR MOVES: FOR ANY DATE YOU'LL BE HELD TO

1 · Record
What happened to things like this? Find 5–40 comparable cases. Pick the class before you look at its answer.

2 · Difference
What makes this one different, and is that evidence or hope? Intentions don't count.

3 · Range
Would you bet 4 to 1? Then widen it for what your frame can't see. Try a premortem: "It failed. Why?"

4 · Score
Write it down with a date. Update in small steps. Check how your 80% calls actually did.

READING YOUR RESULTS SCREEN

- **Your game in 9 facts.** Numbered for a show of hands: your plan, your starting point, what you checked (how often, whether you stopped, and your AI use), the 90% week and the rejections, the scope change, whose numbers you used, whether your range held, money, and luck (your decisions replayed under 100 other draws).
- **The lesson line.** "Your dashboard said week X. The past contracts said week Y. It was accepted in week Z."
- **Your forecast and Delivery.** Three verdicts on your forecast, as on the front, and how the company did.
- **How each tool on the desk would have done,** with what each could and couldn't see.
- **"What your dashboard told you."** The gap between 100% on the dashboard and acceptance is the rework it couldn't see.
- **Download my results (.txt).** Keep it for the discussion; a replay saves as a new run.

TAKE IT WITH YOU

What's one date you've already promised someone this month?

Which frame produced it? _____

What does the record of things like it say? _____

Next week: judge the decision, not the outcome.

Readings: Knight 1921 · Tversky & Kahneman 1974 · Petropoulos et al. 2022 · Mellers et al. 2015 · Schoemaker 1995 · Taleb 2007